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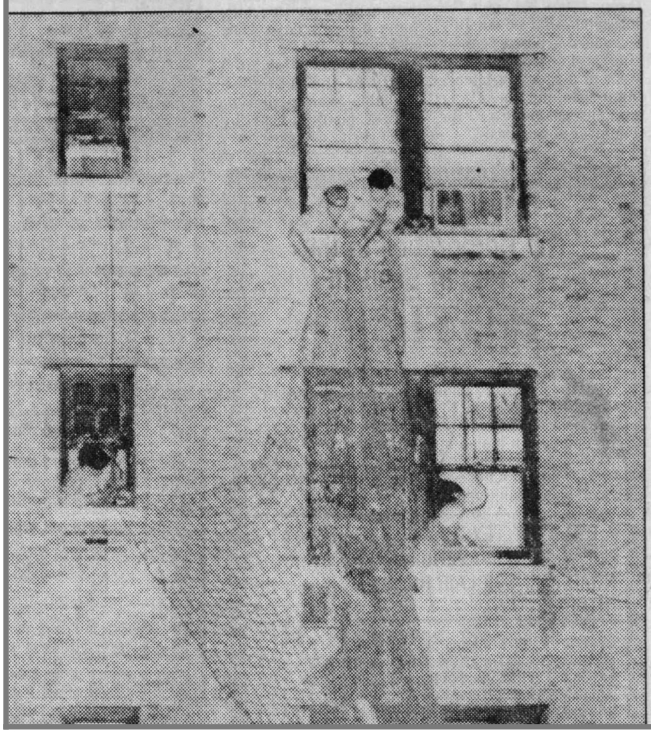
B.C. forest trio buying up Rayonier Canada assets



$420-million joint venture employs 3,000 in province

VANCOUVER (CP) — Three British Columbia-based forest products companies have reached agreement with ITT Industries of Canada to purchase the assets of Rayonier Canada for about $420 million.

B.C. Forest Products Ltd., Doman Industries Ltd. of Duncan and Whonnock Industries Ltd. said they would participate as equal partners in the ownership and operation of the venture, a spokesman for B.C. Forest Products said Thursday.

ITT Industries is a wholly-owned subsidiary of International Telephone and Telegraph Corp. of New York. It has been a liability for the ITT conglomerate, which was forced to write off Rayonier losses of $2.10 U.S. a share last year.

Rayonier Canada operates three sawmills in the Vancouver area, pulp mills at Port Alice on Vancouver Island and Woodfibre on the Sechelt Peninsula north of Vancouver, and has extensive logging operations throughout the province.

It employs about 3,000 people.

Rayonier has two tree farm licences on the northern Island and by itself and with contractors has logging operations at Holberg, Coal Harbour, Port McNeill, Naka Creek, Jeune Landing, Mahatta and Winter Harbour. More logging is done at Jordan River and Gordon River on the southern part of the Island.

The major employment on the Island, however, is at the pulp mill at Port Alice, where about 550 employees produce about 150,000 tons a year. The company last year launched a $50-million improvement program there as part of a $400-million, company-wide, eight-year project.

The sale is subject to departmental approvals by the B.C. government and by the boards of directors of the individual companies. The companies expect the sale to be completed in 60 days.

B.C. Forest Products is a fully integrated forest products company with operations and investments in B.C., Alberta, Quebec and the United States.

Doman and Whonnock are major West Coast lumber producers with operations in coastal B.C. and on the Island.

ITT Industries is also involved in manufacturing automotive parts, telecommunications equipment and industrial products, insurance services and Sheraton hotels.

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